

SILVER STRAINS
Asha Puthli at the Jazz Cafe in London, Aug. 3

FABRICE BOURGELLE-PYRES

At

79, Asha Puthli is having the busiest year of her career. In August, the US-based Indian singer wrapped up her first-ever world tour that covered the US, Australia and the UK and included a main stage slot at the Glastonbury Festival. The end of this month will see the release of acclaimed British-Bahraini dance music duo Dar Disku's self-titled debut album on which she features on the Hindi disco-pop song 'Baar Baar'. Then, in November, she will return to London to play the prestigious 100 Club.

"I guess what motivated me to do it is to show people that you can be creative no matter what age you are," she says over a Zoom call from her home in Palm Beach, Florida, when asked why she decided to take on the rigours of tight touring schedules.

Puthli is a legend of Indian music history whose tunes span jazz, dance, pop, blues, funk and rock. Born and raised in Mumbai, she moved to the US in the 1970s, first gaining attention as the guest vocalist on avant-garde jazz composer Ornette Coleman's album, *Science Fiction* (1972). She went on to make records that are said to have inspired the Munich sound of disco popularised by producer Giorgio Moroder and singer Donna Summer. Though Puthli's pioneering work was critically hailed, she never enjoyed the same level of success as Summer because labels were either reluctant to sign her or didn't know how to market her. "I refused to compromise," recalls Puthli who was advised to change her name to Anne Peters. "I wanted to make it a point that I am Indian."

Her recent resurgence is a consequence of Puthli's music being rediscovered by labels such as the UK's Mr Bongo, which has reissued a couple of her albums and released a best-of compilation, and the US-based Naya Beat, which put out *Disco Mystic*, a collection of remixes of tunes from her first four studio LPs.

Perhaps Puthli was always destined for fame. She spent part of her childhood in Matunga's R.P. Masani Road whose buildings housed such Hindi film celebrities as the Prithviraj Kapoor clan, brothers Amrish and Madan Puri, and K.L. Saigal. When her family shifted to Bandra's Perry Cross Road, her neighbours included Hrishikesh Mukherjee and Salil Chowdhury. Mukherjee wanted her to act in a film but she was already working as an air hostess and had her sights on moving abroad to pursue a singing career. Years later, he would namecheck her through a scene in the movie *Gol Maal* (1979) in which Amol Palekar says he's going for an Asha Puthli concert, recalls the vocalist and fashion icon who did eventually go on to act in the Merchant-Ivory films, *The Guru* (1969) and *Savages* (1972).

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Puthli confirms that all the incredible stories written about her life are true: like how as a teenager in the 1960s, she would perform with her back to the audience so that her parents wouldn't find out. Or how, after months trying to meet him, American music executive John Hammond read about one such